Cause/Problem + Solution: Step by Step

IELTS Writing Task 2 · Band 7 target · 260–300 words

Follow these 9 steps in order for every Cause + Solution or Problem + Solution essay. Each step shows both essay types side by side, so you can see exactly what changes.

Step	What you do	Exam time
1	Find the essay type	0–1 min
2	Underline the exact topic	1–2 min
3	Find 2 causes or 2 problems	2–3 min
4	Match them with 2 solutions, and plan your examples	3–5 min
5	Write the introduction (30–40 words)	5–9 min
6	Write Body Paragraph 1 (90–120 words)	9–19 min
7	Write Body Paragraph 2 (90–120 words)	19–29 min
8	Write the conclusion (30–40 words)	29–34 min
9	Check your essay	34–40 min

> **Word plan: 35 + 105 + 105 + 35 = 280.** Do not write the minimum in every paragraph, because 30 + 90 + 90 + 30 is only 240.
>
> **No opinion is needed** unless the question directly asks for one, so do not write *I think* or *In my opinion*.

The two questions used in every step

> *Cause essay (HEA-09): Walking is known to be beneficial for health and yet fewer and fewer people are walking these days. What are the reasons for this? What can be done to tackle this problem?*

> *Problem essay (TOU-02): As a result of tourism and the increasing number of people travelling, there is a growing demand for more flights. What problems does this cause for the environment? What measures could be taken to solve the problems?*

Step 1: Find the essay type

Do this: read the **first** question only, and ask what it wants you to find.

The first question says	It wants	Essay type
What are the causes / reasons? · Why is this? · Why do you think this is?	**Cause** = কারণ। ঘটনাটি কেন ঘটছে?	**Cause + Solution**
What problems does this cause? · What are the effects / consequences?	**Problem** = সমস্যা বা ক্ষতি। ঘটনাটির ফলে কী ক্ষতি হচ্ছে?	**Problem + Solution**

The second question always wants a **Solution** = সমাধান।

Remember the order:

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   CAUSE       ->       SITUATION       ->       PROBLEM
comes before         the question topic       comes after
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> **সাবধান:** প্রশ্নে *problem* শব্দটি থাকলেই সেটি Problem essay হয় না। প্রথম প্রশ্নটি কী জানতে চাইছে, শুধু সেটি দেখো।

Question	Type	Why
*What are the **reasons** for this? What can be done to tackle this problem?*	**Cause**	The first question asks for reasons. *This problem* only means the topic.
*What **problems** does this cause for the environment? What measures could be taken?*	**Problem**	The first question asks for the harm.

Not sure about an idea? Put it into a test sentence:

Test sentence	If it makes sense, your idea is a
*This situation happens **because** ____.*	**Cause**
***Because of** this situation, ____.*	**Problem**

Step 2: Underline the exact topic

Do this: underline the words that limit your answer. Your ideas must fit these words, not only the general topic.

Question	Underline	So your answer must be about
HEA-09	*fewer people are **walking***	Why people walk less, not why they exercise less in general
TOU-02	*problems **for the environment***	Harm to nature, not expensive tickets or busy airports

Step 3: Find 2 causes or 2 problems

Do this: write 2 ideas, using only a few words for each. Take them from your Idea Bank whenever you can.

Ask yourself	Why does this happen?	What harm does this do?
Idea 1	City streets are unsafe	High carbon emissions
Idea 2	Technology removes the need to walk	Noise and land loss near airports

Cannot find an idea? Check these areas one by one: **money, technology, work and time, education, government, family and society, health, environment.**

Choose simple ideas. Pick the ones you can explain with an example, not the ones that sound most impressive.

Step 4: Match them with 2 solutions, and plan your examples

Do this: ask of each idea, *"What would fix this?"* Then write **WHO** will act and **WHAT** they will do.

In a Cause essay, the solution removes the reason. In a Problem essay, the solution reduces the harm.

Idea 1 → Solution 1	Unsafe streets → **governments** build safe footpaths	Carbon emissions → **governments** introduce fair taxes
Idea 2 → Solution 2	Technology → **workplaces and individuals** bring walking back	Noise and land loss → **governments** invest in high-speed trains

Then plan one example for each paragraph. It goes with Idea 1 and Solution 1. Your finished plan should be this short:

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CAUSE ESSAY (HEA-09)
BP1  C1 unsafe streets     -> parent takes a rickshaw
     C2 technology         -> lifts, online shopping
BP2  S1 safe footpaths     -> same parent walks to the market
     S2 walking in routine -> stairs at work, walk to shops

PROBLEM ESSAY (TOU-02)
BP1  P1 carbon emissions   -> tourist's return flight
     P2 noise, land loss   -> residents, farmland
BP2  S1 fair taxes         -> business traveller uses online calls
     S2 high-speed trains  -> fewer short flights
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Your planning is finished. You now know every idea in your essay.

Step 5: Write the introduction

30–40 words · 2 sentences. Sentence 1 paraphrases the situation. Sentence 2 gives your whole answer.

Sentence 1: the situation in your own words	*Despite its well-known health benefits, walking is becoming less common in modern life.*	*As tourism expands, the demand for air travel continues to rise around the world.*
Sentence 2 formula	*This is mainly because [C1] and [C2], but [S1] and [S2] can tackle this problem.*	*This growth [P1] and [P2], but [S1] and [S2] can reduce these effects.*
Sentence 2	*This is mainly because city streets are unsafe and technology has made it unnecessary, but safer footpaths and better daily habits can tackle this problem.*	*This growth increases carbon emissions and damages areas near airports, but fair environmental taxes and high-speed trains can reduce these effects.*

Do not write: *This essay will discuss the causes and solutions. · In my opinion, … · Although …, but …*

Step 6: Write Body Paragraph 1

90–120 words · 6 sentences · aim for about 105 words. Your first idea gets an example. Your second idea does not, so the paragraph stays within the limit.

Ask yourself: *Explain* = how does it happen? · *Example* = who does it happen to? · *Link* = what is the overall result?

Part	Cause essay	Problem essay
Point	*One of the main causes of this trend is that walking in large cities has become unpleasant and dangerous.*	*The most serious environmental problem caused by this growth is the high level of carbon emissions.*
Explain	*Heavy traffic, air pollution and broken footpaths make short journeys on foot stressful, so many people avoid them.*	*Aeroplanes burn large amounts of fuel, and there are few clean alternatives for long-distance flights at present.*
Example	*For example, a parent who must walk beside fast buses on a broken footpath may take a rickshaw for a five-minute journey, and this soon becomes a habit.*	*For example, a tourist who takes one long-distance return flight can produce as much carbon as several months of driving, and this damage grows as more people travel.*
Point	*Another important cause is technology, which has removed much of the physical effort from daily life.*	*Another problem is the harm that airports cause to the areas around them.*

Part	Cause essay	Problem essay
Explain	*Lifts replace stairs, and online shopping means that people do not even need to walk to the shops.*	*They create noise pollution for nearby residents and take up large areas of land, which may once have been farmland or forest.*
Link	*Consequently, walking has gradually disappeared from the daily routines of many people.*	*Consequently, more flights damage both the global climate and local communities.*

Check your direction:

- **Cause essay:** your explanation moves **towards** the situation: *unsafe streets → stress → people avoid walking*.
- **Problem essay:** your explanation moves **away from** the situation: *more flights → more fuel burned → more carbon*.

The example must show the explanation right before it. *Broken footpaths* appears in both the Explain and the Example sentences above. If the same situation is not in both, change the example.

Too short or too long?	Fix
Under 90 words	Ask *"why?"* or *"what happens next?"* about Idea 2, and add that detail
Over 120 words	Shorten the example. It should be one sentence, not a story

Do not write solutions in this paragraph. Keep them for Step 7.

Step 7: Write Body Paragraph 2

90–120 words · 6 sentences · aim for about 105 words. The shape is the same as BP1, and both essay types work in the same way here.

Every solution needs three things: WHO + WHAT + HOW. *Example* = what would happen to one person? · *Link* = what is the final result?

WHO + WHAT	*Governments should take strict action.*	*The most effective solution is for governments to make streets safer for pedestrians.*
HOW	*Then the problem will be solved.*	*When city planners build safe footpaths and separate them from traffic, walking becomes pleasant and practical rather than stressful.*

Part	Cause essay	Problem essay
Solution	*The most effective solution is for governments to make streets safer for pedestrians.*	*The most effective way to reduce these emissions is to introduce fair environmental taxes, especially for people who fly very frequently.*
Explain	*When city planners build safe footpaths and separate them from traffic, walking becomes pleasant and practical rather than stressful.*	*Higher prices could reduce unnecessary flights, and the money raised could be invested in clean energy.*

Part	Cause essay	Problem essay
Example	*For instance, a parent who can reach the local market on a wide, well-lit footpath may no longer need a rickshaw, which adds exercise to their day at no cost.*	*For instance, a business traveller who pays more for every extra trip may replace some meetings with online calls, which reduces emissions without affecting families who rarely fly.*
Solution	*In addition, employers and individuals can bring walking back into everyday routines.*	*In addition, governments could invest in high-speed trains for shorter journeys.*
Explain	*Workplaces can encourage staff to use the stairs, while people can walk to nearby shops instead of ordering online, and these small changes quickly add up.*	*When passengers have a fast and comfortable alternative, short flights become less necessary, so airports cause less noise and need less new land.*
Link	*Together, these measures would make walking a normal part of modern life again.*	*Together, these measures would allow people to travel while causing far less environmental damage.*

Use careful language. Solutions have not happened yet, so use *should, could, can, would*. Do not write *This will completely solve the problem*.

Use a realistic example, not a fake fact. Describe what would happen to one person. Never invent a statistic, a study or an expert.

Step 8: Write the conclusion

30–40 words · 2 sentences. Use the same ideas in new words, and add no new idea.

Sentence 1 formula	*In conclusion, [situation] because [C1] and [C2].*	*In conclusion, [situation] harms [P1] and [P2].*
Sentence 1	*In conclusion, people walk less because urban streets are hazardous and technology has reduced physical effort.*	*In conclusion, rising demand for flights harms the climate and the communities living near airports.*
Sentence 2 formula	*[S1] and [S2] would [final result].*	*[S1] and [S2] would [final result].*
Sentence 2	*Safer pedestrian routes and small changes to everyday habits would encourage more people to walk regularly.*	*Well-designed taxes and better rail connections would limit this damage without preventing people from travelling.*

Step 9: Check your essay

Use your last 6 minutes in this order.

1. Check your answer

☐ BP1 answers the first question, and BP2 answers the second.
☐ My causes or problems pass the test sentence from Step 1.
☐ BP1 has no solutions, and BP2 has no new causes or problems.
☐ Every solution has WHO + WHAT + HOW.
☐ Each example shows the explanation right before it.
☐ I wrote no opinion, and no *This essay will …* sentence.

2. Check your language

☐ Articles (*a, an, the*) and plurals (*-s*)
☐ Subject–verb agreement (*people are, a person is*)
☐ No *but* after *Although* or *While*
☐ Spelling: *conclusion, sentence, government, environment*

3. Check your length

☐ About 280 words in total: at least 260, and no more than 300 in practice.

See the Complete Essays

Essay A: Cause + Solution (294 words)

Walking is known to be beneficial for health and yet fewer and fewer people are walking these days. What are the reasons for this? What can be done to tackle this problem?

Introduction · 38 words

Despite its well-known health benefits, walking is becoming less common in modern life. This is mainly because city streets are unsafe and technology has made it unnecessary, but safer footpaths and better daily habits can tackle this problem.

Body Paragraph 1: Causes · 111 words

Point One of the main causes of this trend is that walking in large cities has become unpleasant and dangerous. Explain Heavy traffic, air pollution and broken footpaths make short journeys on foot stressful, so many people avoid them. Example For example, a parent who must walk beside fast buses on a broken footpath may take a rickshaw for a five-minute journey, and this soon becomes a habit. Point Another important cause is technology, which has removed much of the physical effort from daily life. Explain Lifts replace stairs, and online shopping means that people do not even need to walk to the shops. Link Consequently, walking has gradually disappeared from the daily routines of many people.

Body Paragraph 2: Solutions · 113 words

Solution The most effective solution is for governments to make streets safer for pedestrians. Explain When city planners build safe footpaths and separate them from traffic, walking becomes pleasant and practical rather than stressful. Example For instance, a parent who can reach the local market on a wide, well-lit footpath may no longer need a rickshaw, which adds exercise to their day at no cost. Solution In addition, employers and individuals can bring walking back into everyday routines. Explain Workplaces can encourage staff to use the stairs, while people can walk to nearby shops instead of ordering online, and these small changes quickly add up. Link Together, these measures would make walking a normal part of modern life again.

Conclusion · 32 words

In conclusion, people walk less because urban streets are hazardous and technology has reduced physical effort. Safer pedestrian routes and small changes to everyday habits would encourage more people to walk regularly.

Essay B: Problem + Solution (285 words)

As a result of tourism and the increasing number of people travelling, there is a growing demand for more flights. What problems does this cause for the environment? What measures could be taken to solve the problems?

Introduction · 35 words

As tourism expands, the demand for air travel continues to rise around the world. This growth increases carbon emissions and damages areas near airports, but fair environmental taxes and high-speed trains can reduce these effects.

Body Paragraph 1: Problems · 107 words

Point The most serious environmental problem caused by this growth is the high level of carbon emissions. Explain Aeroplanes burn large amounts of fuel, and there are few clean alternatives for long-distance flights at present. Example For example, a tourist who takes one long-distance return flight can produce as much carbon as several months of driving, and this damage grows as more people travel. Point Another problem is the harm that airports cause to the areas around them. Explain They create noise pollution for nearby residents and take up large areas of land, which may once have been farmland or forest. Link Consequently, more flights damage both the global climate and local communities.

Body Paragraph 2: Solutions · 113 words

Solution The most effective way to reduce these emissions is to introduce fair environmental taxes, especially for people who fly very frequently. Explain Higher prices could reduce unnecessary flights, and the money raised could be invested in clean energy. Example For instance, a business traveller who pays more for every extra trip may replace some meetings with online calls, which reduces emissions without affecting families who rarely fly. Solution In addition, governments could invest in high-speed trains for shorter journeys. Explain When passengers have a fast and comfortable alternative, short flights become less necessary, so airports cause less noise and need less new land. Link Together, these measures would allow people to travel while causing far less environmental damage.

Conclusion · 30 words

In conclusion, rising demand for flights harms the climate and the communities living near airports. Well-designed taxes and better rail connections would limit this damage without preventing people from travelling.

Your Turn: Practice

Do Practice 1 and Practice 2 on different days. Complete Steps 1–4 here in 5 minutes, then write the full essay in 35 minutes. **Do not look at the Suggested Plans until you finish.**

Practice 1

> *The crime rate in most countries is often higher in urban areas than in rural areas. Why do you think that is? What can be done to reduce the crime rate? (CRI-13)*

Step	My plan
1. Essay type	
2. Exact topic	
3. Idea 1	
3. Idea 2	
4. Solution 1: WHO + WHAT	
4. Solution 2: WHO + WHAT	
4. Example for BP1	
4. Example for BP2	

Practice 2

Large businesses have big budgets for marketing and promotion, and as a result, people gravitate towards buying their products. What problems does this cause? What could be done to encourage people to buy local products? (BUS-06)

Step	My plan
1. Essay type	
2. Exact topic	
3. Idea 1	
3. Idea 2	
4. Solution 1: WHO + WHAT	
4. Solution 2: WHO + WHAT	
4. Example for BP1	
4. Example for BP2	

Suggested Plans

Check these only after you finish your own plan. They are one good answer, not the only right one. Your plan is also correct if your ideas pass the test sentence and answer the exact question.

Practice 1: CRI-13

Step	Suggested plan
1. Essay type	**Cause + Solution.** *Why do you think that is?* asks for reasons, not your opinion.
2. Exact topic	Why crime is **higher in cities** than in rural areas, not why crime happens in general
3. Idea 1	Rich and poor neighbourhoods side by side, so poverty and temptation are stronger
3. Idea 2	People do not know their neighbours, so criminals are not recognised
4. Solution 1	**Governments** create jobs and youth programmes in poor neighbourhoods
4. Solution 2	**Communities** organise neighbourhood watch groups
4. Example for BP1	A jobless young person living beside a wealthy area is tempted to steal
4. Example for BP2	The same young person joins a job training programme
Idea Bank	Chapter 07 Crime → *Crime in Cities and Crime Prevention*

Practice 2: BUS-06

Step	Suggested plan
1. Essay type	**Problem + Solution.** *What problems does this cause?* asks for the harm.
2. Exact topic	Problems from big companies' marketing. Solutions must encourage people to **buy local products**.
3. Idea 1	Local shops lose customers and may close
3. Idea 2	Profits leave the local economy
4. Solution 1	**Governments** give local producers small loans and business training, so that they can improve quality and compete
4. Solution 2	**Public campaigns** show that buying local keeps money in the community
4. Example for BP1	A family-run grocery loses customers when a large supermarket opens
4. Example for BP2	The same grocery improves its products and packaging with a small loan
Idea Bank	Chapter 10 Culture → *Multinational Companies versus Local Business* · Chapter 06 Work → *Self-Employment and Entrepreneurship*